

Curated & Organized by @MxBlackifyanasty + @Dandelion.Hill



SURVIVAL GUIDE FOR THE BURNT OUT ACTIVIST

**A LIVED EXPERIENCE OFFERING
FOR ORGANIZERS, ACTIVISTS,
& THOSE ENGAGED IN COMMUNITY CARE**

PERSPECTIVES ON BURNOUT FROM DANDELION & KLEOPATRA

We wanted to create this because we are deeply tired, our comrades are exhausted, our community members - we see them doing their best and simultaneously depleting their wells. In a time when more and more folks are turning towards organizing, community care, and mutual aid - the rewards are high and so too is the risk for burnout.

We don't have all the answers, but we believe deeply in collective wisdom so included herein are some offerings from folks with lived experience that we hope might offer some sense of solidarity and launching points for those seeking direction.

It's rough out here. Our sustainability is so vitally important. Your exhaustion, it's valid. Please be gentle with yourselves and one another.

PERSPECTIVES ON BURNOUT FROM DANDELION & KLEOPATRA

Burnout is too often looked at as individual exhaustion versus systemic exploitation and we want to name that we don't subscribe to that framework. Rather, we recognize that many are forced beyond their limits under the contexts of capitalism and unrelenting demands to meet in order to survive.

Gentle reminder from us to you (in case you need to hear it, we know we often do) that burnout is not a personal failing nor is it easy to resolve when our basic needs are unmet.



It was shocking to us how easily our comrades were able to access language for burnout as it showed up in themselves, as if the feeling had become so recurrent – the familiarity of a dysfunctional home speaking a resounding testament to the nature of the times we are in. All of these responses are from folks with lived experience and we received them within 24 hours of posing the question:

**“WHAT DOES IT LOOK LIKE
WHEN YOU’RE BURNT OUT?”**



"WHAT DOES IT LOOK LIKE WHEN YOU'RE BURNT OUT?"*

***lived experience responses**

"When I'm burning out, I tend to be more irritable than usual, nothing brings me joy, and I usually want to eat and sleep more than usual"

"I have low tolerance. I want to sleep all the time and eat junk food."

"I know for me I'm exhausted and unable to fully process a lot of new information when I'm feeling burnt out. Everything makes me want to cry or throw something at a wall."

**"Irritable! Angry! Short
tempered! And often
disassociated!"**

"Throwing myself further into work, doing only activism, until the consequences catch up to me"

**“Waking with that “groundhog day” feeling,
first thing in the morning, every morning.
Like life and work is one forever liminal
hallway.”**

**“My burnout has been evolving into
depression so there's some overlap here,
but; 1) I feel like I'm on the threshold of tears
a lot, 2) I can make all the to do lists I want,
but being able to actually DO the work feels
completely impossible, 3) no amount of rest
makes me feel refreshed 4) I no longer react
emotionally to things that would normally
bring about an emotional response”**

**“Self Isolation, avoiding events,
resentment, hopelessness.”**

**“Zero motivation, everything feels
discouraging, sometimes even something
inside me begins to resist the desire to do
things I usually want to or need to do.”**

**“when every little thing feels
overwhelming. and it feels like
I can't keep my head above
water, and no energy to try”**

"When I'm in deep limerence and feel like I need to escape my mind. A kind of tired that sleep doesn't satiate."

"Anxiety, depression, aggressive intrusive thoughts, feeling the need to isolate and avoiding texts/messages/social interactions. If burnout persists for an extended period, I start getting substance cravings, the urge to self-injure to regulate, and suicidality comes into play."

"I cry so much and get irritated quickly"

"I know for me I'm exhausted and unable to fully process a lot of new information when I'm feeling burnt out. Everything makes me want to cry or throw something at a wall."

"WHAT DOES IT LOOK LIKE WHEN YOU'RE BURNT OUT?"*

***lived experience responses**

"Burnout can manifest in all kinds of ways for me, here's just a few signs that I've noticed:

- Existing feels like swimming through soup
- Physical stress manifesting in how my body feels/moves (Tension in my muscles, clenching my teeth, etc.)
- Low tolerance for last minute changes in plans, no matter how small
- Everything makes me want to cry
- A feeling of dread when additional tasks are added to my plate
- Feeling like I can't slow down, fear of losing momentum
- Feeling exhausted all the time
- Anxiety/depression symptoms spike
- Increased irritability
- struggles to remember things and process information/ learn new information"

**"Exhausted & unmotivated,
beating myself up for 'not
doing enough' "**

"When I start fantasizing about something happening to me that would require me taking time off – getting hurt, breaking a bone, getting sick..."

"short fuse. short temper. avoidance of tasks or waiting until the last moment. brain fog. exhaustion that has no beginning or end. isolating myself from my loved ones. being trapped in a freeze cycle. not cooking my meals or cleaning dishes. being on autopilot & incapable of accessing pleasure"

"When I have no gratitude – when I'm dreading the work I am passionate about – when I start losing track of my todo list and forgetting appointments / engagements I planned – when I struggle to feed myself – when I start fantasizing about entire days off...."

"WHAT DOES IT LOOK LIKE WHEN YOU'RE BURNT OUT?"*

***lived experience responses**

“When I start comparing myself to other people (I’m not doing enough, how do they have so much energy?). When I start getting nihilistic instead of existential (moving to we’re all just specs on a grain of sand, nothing matters instead of moving to we’re all just specs on a grain of sand, we make it matter). I look at my to do list and I feel paralyzed trying to figure out where to start. I spend more time on social.

“When i don’t wanna talk to nobody and don’t wanna leave the house (so basically when I act like a liberal)”

I get irritable and touchy, I notice self care tasks like showering, exercising, sleeping on time start to slip. Inability to stick to plans that aren't absolutely necessary (basically anything that I don't need to do to pay the bills)

"WHAT DOES IT LOOK LIKE WHEN YOU'RE BURNT OUT?"*

***lived experience responses**

"I feel tired tired tired. It's harder to eat properly and maintain a clean space. I tend to become more critical and doomerist and judge others and myself more harshly. Sideation and sh urges increase and it's harder to reach out for support (esp following times when I know my comrades are also experiencing burnout)"

"Doom scrolling, big guilt and shame feelings, "stuck" on social interactions, numb."

"Loss of sense of humor"

"irritable, in pain, overwhelmed by even basic choices/responsibilities, more likely to burst into tears, feeling numb and empty, increased need to be alone, increased suicidality, feeling like im going thru the motions-- and each step is like wading through syrup. unable to contribute to conversations, eating less frequently/not responding to bodily cues. neglecting hygiene."

A NOTE ON CAPACITY & MAKING SPACE

Some of us will have a lower baseline for capacity – be it from Disability, being a caretaker, from facing harsher oppression, or any number of valid, interplaying reasons.

For those folks, **simply existing can cause burn out.** What you have and can give is enough – you are still an invaluable part of the ecosystem even if you can't *give* and all your internal resources are being used for survival.

A gentle invitation from those who have more capacity to give, be it from having a higher baseline innately or because you hold more privilege – please be mindful not to leave behind those of us with less to give in our movement and community care efforts. No one is disposable and in-line with rejecting capitalism + hyper individualism it feels important to name that our value isn't tied to what we can do. **We all belong & must make space for one another.**

"HOW DO YOU TAKE CARE OF YOURSELF WHEN YOU'RE BURNT OUT?"*

*lived experience responses

*Note: take what resonates & leave what doesn't
- what works for one might fail for some.*

"Sitting with the discomfort of asking for support! Specifically, with eating! Eating and hydrating are the first two things to slip when feeling burnt out. The more they slip, the quicker the burn out hits. So practicing reaching out to supports for food support is huge. Whether it be a text reminder asking if I've eaten or hydrated; handing me a glass of water after an action/ busy day; inviting me out to share a meal/ go for a walk to get a snack. All huge for me! "

"Spend time in nature (even if it's just laying on some grass in a backyard, you know? Make it the easiest version of the thing)"

"set boundaries. find accountability buddies. unplug to decompress. moving my body. resting. spending time outside. sunshine on my face. cuddles."

"Sleep and shower, sleep and wash my face, sleep and brush my teeth."

"Lessen responsibilities, get support from loved ones, and focus on my basic needs before moving up to more complex/energy-taking activities (that I want to do but feel like I can't)"

"Sleep. Show compassion for myself and my moods. Focus on basic things like personal hygiene. Don't force myself to do anything I don't want to do that isn't absolutely necessary. Increase my therapy sessions if possible."

"HOW DO YOU TAKE CARE OF YOURSELF WHEN YOU'RE BURNT OUT?"*

***lived experience responses**

"HOW DO YOU TAKE CARE OF YOURSELF WHEN YOU'RE BURNT OUT?"*

***lived experience responses**

"Reduce demands. Offload them where you can, outright ignore them where you have to. Become friends with your special interests. Eat what is accessible. Sleep, and then sleep some more. Don't talk to people who will only stress you out and judge you more, if you can. Find people you can relate to and listen to their strategies, and also revel in not being alone. Rest more than you want to. Work on unlearning shame, once you're ready"

"I slow down!! Get extra rest, take naps when I can. Make time for things I enjoy just bc I enjoy them. Also take a moment to ask myself if i need to reassess my responsibilities/workload. do i need to make changes or do less stuff? making those changes can help it from happening again"

"Make art"

"Say no a ton even to things I want. Sleep, less serious activities or responsibilities, releasing self judgment if I can. Not taking on new responsibilities and scaling back existing ones."

"Slowing down, if nothing else works anyway I might as well!"

"Seek supports in my friends and my wife. I have mad FOMO so I have to cancel events and then care for that FOMO that comes with it. Eat what I want when I want and if that means going into overdraft for takeout then I am fed and can deal with the rest later. I limit my doom scrolling which can make it so much worse. I seek love from animal around me. I do the standard colour, movie, and easy brain activity. I remind myself to do tasks slower, slow down and chew my food, slow down and don't rush out the door."

"@arabjewishcoalitionforpeace has in their links a burnout guide/journal created in response to a forest defence campaign on my home isle a few years ago that I always recommend to folks."

"recognize that it is valid + rational to be burnt out in an ecosystem that demands the inhumane then carve out the space that I need, unapologetically."

"Sleep sleep and more sleep! It helps me reset my brain sometimes. Rest is productive"

"Slowing down, slow intentional breathing, yoga, meditation, focus on fulfilling basic needs like eating and hydrating, getting a good night's sleep to reset my mindset, skincare routine, calming scents from candles and bath bombs, spending time in the garden/nature, going on a walk, spending time with animal companions, offloading/reducing tasks, get support from loved ones"

"HOW DO YOU TAKE CARE OF YOURSELF WHEN YOU'RE BURNT OUT?"*

***lived experience responses**

THANK YOU!

Thank you to all of those who offered their wisdom + perspectives for this communal resource. We couldn't fit all of the beautiful answers into this offering, but if you'd like to check out all of the responses you can visit:

tinyurl.com/BurntOutResponses

We believe deeply in the power of shared lived experiences and not gatekeeping information. As such, this offering is free & we welcome folks to share it widely with whoever might benefit from it. If you want to give resources as a thank you - we invite you to give to individual or collective mutual aid efforts.

